

Factions and Connections: The Web of Influence

In *Zero Sum*, the “monsters” are institutions. They are vast, decentralized, and often work in parallel or in secret conflict with one another. Below are the primary power players in the 2026 landscape.

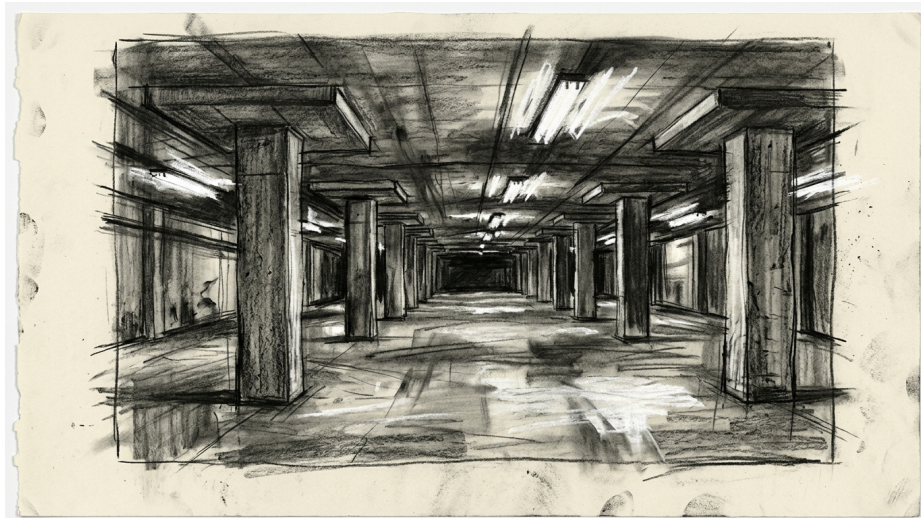
1. The Surveillance State (Intelligence Agencies)

These aren't rogue agents; they are the system working exactly as designed. * **The “Five Eyes” Apparatus:** A massive, automated dragnet of global communications. In the game, they aren't looking at the players personally until the Heat Level gets too high. * **Key Tactics:** Signal interception, freezing assets, “Parallel Construction” (using illegal surveillance to find evidence, then lying about how they found it to use in court).

2. Private Intelligence & Cyber Mercenaries

Corporate equivalents of intelligence agencies, offering deniable operations to the highest bidder. * **Aegis Analytics:** A data-mining firm that weaponizes social media data and psychological profiling to rig elections and destroy reputations. * **Vanguard Solutions:** Purveyors of military-grade spyware (similar to Pegasus/NSO Group). They sell zero-click smartphone exploits to authoritarian regimes and nervous billionaires.

3. High Finance & “Dark Money”



Dark Money

The people who actually run the world. They don't use guns; they use algorithmic trading and offshore tax havens. * **The Sovereign Wealth Syndicates:** Trillions of dollars hidden in shell companies across the Cayman Islands, Delaware, and Swiss Freeports. They will eliminate anyone who threatens their financial secrecy. * **The “Fixers”:** Law firms and wealth managers in London and New York who specialize in hiding assets and legally harassing journalists into silence.

4. The Underground & Resistance

The players' potential allies, though none are entirely trustworthy. * **The Decentralized Web (Hacktivists):** Loose collectives of hackers. They have useful tools but are constantly infiltrated by federal informants. * **Zero-Day Brokers:** Information merchants who buy and sell software vulnerabilities. They are strictly neutral and incredibly expensive. * **The Grey Market:** Smugglers, forgers, and ex-military logistics experts who operate outside the traditional banking system, running on cryptocurrency and favors.

The Web of Connections

In *Zero Sum*, factions constantly overlap. A politician (Faction 1) might hire a Cyber Mercenary (Faction 2) paid for by Dark Money (Faction 3) to discredit a Hacktivist (Faction 4). The GM should always map out at least three degrees of separation between the players and the “Big Boss” of a scenario.